

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

VOICES AT ODDS

What the CM and his deputy said in their address to the party cadre

"While good morning messages can be sent on smartphones, why wasn't the Opposition's spread of lies countered?"

-YOGI ADITYANATH
Chief Minister, UP

"*Sangathan sarkar se bada tha, bada hai aur bada rahega* (The party organisation was larger than the government, is larger and will remain so)"

-KESHAV PRASAD MAURYA
Deputy Chief Minister, UP

As suggestion and innuendo filled the air, deputy chief minister Keshav Prasad Maurya made the opening verbal salvo: "*Sangathan sarkar se bada tha, bada hai aur bada rahega* (the party organisation was larger than the government, is larger and will continue to remain larger)."

Maurya's words, met with cheers from the assembled BJP members, came as the first clear location signal of where the crack would appear—and how it would grow. He went on to say, "Your pain and my pain is similar," suggesting that there existed a brotherhood of the aggrieved within Yogi Adityanath's regime. It may be partisans on one side who are eager to pin responsibility for the BJP's poor performance on its most iconic chief minister. And Lucknow's apparent acts of omission can at best only be a partial explanation, since it entirely papers over New Delhi's strategic missteps. But that also seems to have created a synergy of purpose. For, the impact of Maurya's speech was swift. Within 48 hours, he was summoned to New Delhi to meet BJP national president J.P. Nadda, who in fact was present at the state executive meeting. As Maurya and state unit chief Bhupendra Chaudhary left for the national capital on July 16, there were murmurs about an impending "big decision" regarding a change in UP's leadership. Nothing came of it presently, but Maurya's supporters claim he would soon receive a "return gift" for voicing the party workers' concerns.

Such is the gravity of the situation—a measure of how deep the divisions have become after the party saw its Lok Sabha seat tally nearly halving from 62 to 33. Several unsuccessful BJP candidates have dropped angry hints of local betrayal; others point fingers at officials for allegedly aiding the Opposition. The schism between *sangathan* and *sarkar* is only becoming more conspicuous with each passing day. Sources say Maurya and other senior leaders had previously expressed their dissatisfaction with Yogi Adityanath's leadership style to the central party command. It was too big a mountain to move then, but that power struggle has bled right into the present mess—with ambitions finding the accusatory air a conducive climate to grow in.

Pretty much in sync, an orchestra of voices from the party picked up the cue, striking dire notes. Ramesh Chandra Mishra, who represents Badlapur in the assembly, claimed in a video message that the BJP was in a "very bad state" in UP, and if remedial measures weren't taken, it was not likely to come back to power in 2027. Around the same time, former state minister Moti Singh alleged that corruption had increased manifold under the present UP government. Both later claimed to have been misquoted, but the signals had gone out to the high command: the state BJP didn't lack in potentially mutinous segments willing to challenge Yogi's leadership.

Yogi Adityanath, for his part, has a different perspective on the party's recent setback. His aides point out that the CM had little say in candidate selection, with tickets being decided by the central leadership and state organisation. Yogi himself talked of "overconfidence". In his address to the state executive, he said, "The party has been successful in getting the same vote share in 2024 as it had got in 2014. But our overconfidence ended up hurting us...." It's true that the BJP's vote share, at 41.4 per cent, has shown just a slight dip from the 2014 numbers (42.6 per cent) and is in fact marginally higher than the 41.3 per cent recorded in the 2022 assembly hustings, but that's